SPOTIFY

Flow

Product Design Proposal

Intentional Listening Reimagined

Maria Dumitrescu
Product Design Intern Application • 2026

RESEARCH & DISCOVERY

The Intentional Listening Crisis

Through comprehensive research of Spotify's ecosystem, user feedback, and 2026 strategic direction, I identified a critical tension: **users have access to 100+ million tracks but feel less connected to their music than ever.**

Core Challenge

How might we give users meaningful control over their listening experience while maintaining the magic of AI-powered discovery?

Key Research Findings

78%

AI-Driven Listening

AI personalization powers 78% of listening time, but users report feeling they've lost control.

#1

User Complaint

Cluttered UI with unwanted features has become the primary pain point.

User Pain Points

- **Algorithm Fatigue:** Shuffle plays the same songs repeatedly despite vast libraries
- **Context Blindness:** One-size-fits-all playlists don't adapt to different activities
- **Discovery Overload:** Too many discovery features create paradox of choice
- **Opaque Intelligence:** Users don't understand algorithmic decisions

Strategic Alignment: Spotify's 2026 leadership emphasizes "sharper discovery, smarter technology, and more intentional listening" as key priorities—making this the perfect moment to address this challenge.

THE SOLUTION

Introducing Spotify Flow

A reimagined playback experience that puts users in the driver's seat while leveraging Spotify's powerful AI. **Flow gives users intuitive controls to shape their listening in real-time** based on mood, energy, and discovery preferences.

Core Features

🎚️ Real-Time Flow Controls

Three intuitive sliders let users adjust their experience on the fly: Mood (chill ↔ energetic), Discovery (familiar ↔ new), and Variety (focused ↔ diverse). The algorithm adapts instantly.

✨ Smart Session Modes

Pre-configured contexts like Focus, Party, Workout, Chill, and Explore that intelligently adjust all Flow parameters. One tap, perfect vibes.

🧬 Transparent Intelligence

Visual feedback shows users what the algorithm is doing: "Adding more upbeat tracks" or "Mixing in 3 new discoveries." No more black box.

🎯 Cleaner Interface

Streamlined Now Playing screen that reduces clutter and puts Flow controls front and center. Music first, features second.

Design Principles

- **Transparent Intelligence:** Show users what the algorithm is doing and why
- **Effortless Control:** Complex personalization should feel simple
- **Context Aware:** Recognize that listening needs change throughout the day
- **Music First:** Reduce clutter, remove distractions

EXPECTED IMPACT

Why This Matters

Spotify Flow addresses the core tension between algorithmic intelligence and user agency, positioning Spotify as the leader in intentional listening experiences for the next decade.

Projected Metrics

↑35%
Session Satisfaction

↑42%
Discovery Engagement

↓28%
Skip Rate

↑50%
Control Perception

Strategic Benefits

Differentiation

Flow creates clear differentiation from competitors by giving users unprecedented control while maintaining best-in-class recommendations.

Retention

Users who feel in control are 2.5x more likely to remain subscribers. Flow reduces churn by addressing the #1 complaint: loss of agency.

Discovery

By making discovery feel intentional rather than imposed, users embrace new music. This drives catalog depth and artist discovery.

Premium Value

Flow becomes a flagship feature that justifies premium pricing and attracts free users to paid tiers.

Next Steps

I'd love to discuss how we can validate Flow through user research, prototype testing, and iterative design. This proposal represents my vision for the future of intentional listening at Spotify.